



Samsung SCX-4521F

exceptions here were the Samsung SCX-4100 and SCX-4521F, which recognised two and three letters wrongly, respectively. This may not seem much, but the figure will rise if the volume of OCR scanning is high.

Copying

The copier test was once again jointly won by the Samsung SCX-4521F and Xerox PE220, which posted the lowest copy times and the best quality. The Samsung SF-565P was the slowest of the lot, because it only had a sheet-fed scanner which is inherently slower.

The Digit Awards Go To...

The Samsung SCX-4521 came with a decent software bundle, performed extremely well, and also scored well in the features department. In terms of print and scan quality, it was better than the Xerox. The lower price tag of Rs 21,990 was also a deciding factor, and we awarded the Samsung SCX-4521 the Digit Best Buy Gold for monochrome laser MFDs.

Looking at the rather high Rs 26,500 price tag, we didn't think the Xerox PE220 would win an award. But considerably higher scores in the features department, a good software bundle, and very good performance fetched the Xerox WorkCentre PE220 the Digit Best Buy Silver award in this category.

So Where Do We Go From Here?

MFDs have been traditionally known to perform not as well as standalone products. Also, if one part of an MFD goes defunct, the entire unit ceases to work, this is especially true in cases such as when a scanner ceases working, the fax and copier do not work or if the printer has a

problem, the copier also cannot work. But with advances in technology and improvements in design, the chances of components going out of order have been reduced.

We are set to see a lot of exciting innovations in the laser MFD segment in the next few years. LEP (liquid electro-photographic) technology, which is used in high-end digital printing presses, has the potential to revolutionise office and home printing alike.

Other innovations such as printing over wireless are already on their way to market.

With the use of Wi-Fi gaining popularity in offices, Wi-Fi-capable MFDs will be the devices to look for in the near future. Direct printing from cell phones is another possibility that is being explored.

Quite a few innovations are underway in the field of multifunction copiers. Some already have CPUs, RAM and hard drives! Certain technologies, such as Canon's Multifunc-



Xerox Workcentre PE220

tional Embedded Application Platform (MEAP) J2ME Java-based technology, enables customised business applications to be created and installed on the device. These can be easily controlled via the MFD user interface. As an example, using a MEAP application installed on a device, a bank could "train" the device to differentiate between a home loan, personal loan and credit card application, and where to electronically route the scanned paperwork for processing and approval. Such technologies will help future-proof the multifunction copier.

While it does not seem likely—even by a long shot—that the prices of laser MFDs will drop to levels comparable to those of inkjet MFDs, they are sure to plummet.

Manufacturers are certainly doing their bit in reducing sizes, and some are already almost as small as inkjet MFDs.

With dropping prices, colour laser MFDs, which as of now are too expensive for the SoHo and SMB segments, may make an entry the next time round. ☐

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Contact Sheet

Laser MFDs

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